

WP 7200

The WP class of steam locomotives were designed to be express passenger engines. With a 4-6-2 wheel arrangement and a speed of up to 100 km/h, the WP 7200 was one of the 16 prototypes imported from the Baldwin Locomotive Works in the US in 1947. It was inducted into the Indian Railway's steam fleet on 15 August 1947 – Independence Day – aptly earning the name *Azad*, meaning free. India began production of this class of locomotives in 1963 and the [Chittaranjan Locomotive Works](#) in West Bengal became the first to manufacture them in the country. While electric locomotives were operational in and around the city of Bombay by the early 20th century, they never really reached the speed of 100 km/h.

Azad has a distinctive cone-shaped bulging nose with a gleaming silver star painted on it. Its dimensions were designed keeping in mind the poor track conditions across the country in the late 1940s. The WP class of locomotives served as the standard broad-gauge locomotives for more than four decades till they were retired in 1995.

In a bid to revive the charm of the classic steam-hauled trains and locomotives, *Azad* was restored at the Rewari Heritage Steam Loco Centre, Haryana, by a dedicated team of the Northern Railway. It began hauling a Sunday commercial steam train service between Farukh Nagar and Gadi Harsaru in Haryana in 2018. The 11-km ride is specially aimed at steam engine enthusiasts, generating tourist traffic and serving up a slice of steam heritage. On 21 November 2018, *Azad* was used to pull one of the world's most luxurious and iconic trains – [Palace on Wheels](#) for its 12th tour – on a short trip from the Safdarjung Station to the Patel Nagar Station in Delhi. The vintage locomotive was also used to haul a passenger train for a special tour from the New Delhi Station to the Delhi Junction during the Indian Railways' 63rd Railway Week in 2018. This tour was specially curated for differently abled children.